Diploma in UX Design

User onboarding

Summary Notes

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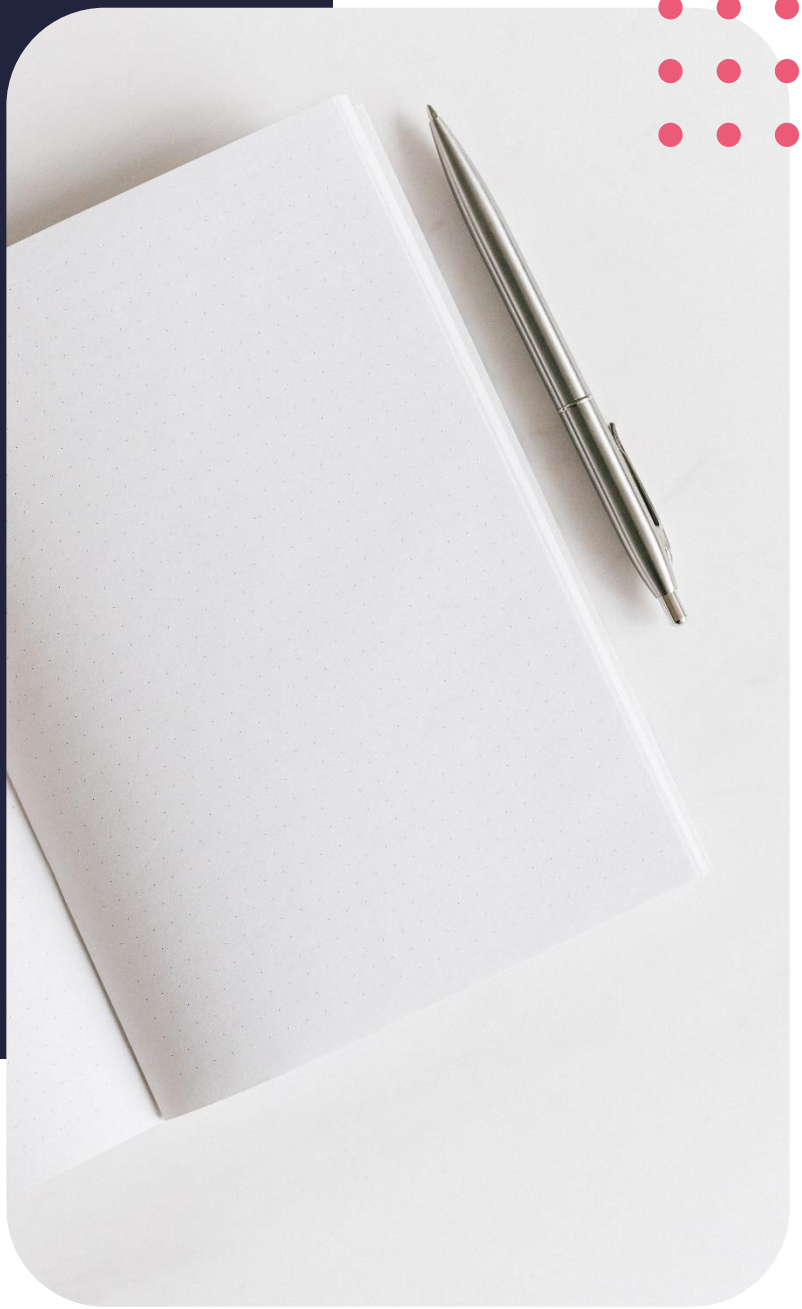

Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Understand user onboarding
- Investigate the steps to user onboarding

Introduction

User onboarding is a crucial aspect of UX Design, and every UX designer must know how to master the art of the broader onboarding process. This starts with clear awareness creation about your product for non-users, quick and easy adoption by new users and continual improvement of efficiency as you introduce new features to advanced users.

User onboarding is also important for marketing or to simply expand your user base. A poor onboarding process is often the main reason why people won't become a customer or long-term user of your product.

What is user onboarding?

User onboarding is the process of assisting a potential new user to become an actual user of your product. User onboarding is closely related to digital adoption. Digital adoption is the process to help digital laggards (individuals reluctant to adopt digital products but rather stick to traditional ways) to start using modern digital tools in their personal or work life. Digital adoption is particularly important in the socio-economic development and the modernisation of communities. Often the solution to people's problems may be an app, which could help them save time, money or improve their productivity or quality of life, but they just don't know of your product or are too hesitant to learn to use it. An important part of onboarding is to help potential users to become aware of your solution, how easy it is to start using it, how much it will help them, and to make it very easy to start using it productively.

A common misconception is that user onboarding starts once the user is signing up and ends after the initial product tour or onboarding messages. Onboarding **starts with awareness creation that the app exists and that it could make the user's life easier or better** through some form of value creation. Onboarding **never ends**, or at least live as long as the product is still maintained, improved and updated. Users must be constantly and gradually educated in a fun, informal, intuitive manner to use **continually more advanced features** as they become power users and to use any new features that are added to keep the app modern and engaging.

User onboarding steps

These steps entail converting people from non-users to engaged and loyal power users.

Step 1: Knowing wo to convert

We need to understand the potential or target users before a customer attraction and conversion strategy can be developed. Your target audience may be the existing customers of traditional brick-and-mortar businesses. These are businesses that are not digital, like traditional banks or retailers. They make primarily use of branches instead of digital channels for basic transactions that could easily be completely migrated to digital channels. These are the late adopters in the technology diffusion model of innovation and can be known as conservatives, laggards, or sceptics. These customers

need special marketing and other interventions to accelerate digital adoption of your non-traditional or digital channels. This is because it may be much cheaper and more efficient for you to serve them digitally.

Your target users may also be people who are already familiar with digital technologies. This will make your digital adoption efforts much easier, but the competition you face from other apps or digital product providers may be much stronger.

To know the different market segments to target, you must investigate the following:

- Problems your target users are seeking solutions for
- Tasks or goals your target users wish to accomplish
- Current vs ideal ways to enhance and satisfy their needs, and associated pain points that should be eliminated or reduced.
- Their deeper motivations and interests
- Personality and socio-graphic characteristics of your most interested or profitable user segments
- The most effective marketing and awareness channels these target users can be reached

Step 2: Profiling primary, secondary and tertiary personas or segments targeted for conversion

Your digital product cannot offer every type of service to everyone, there is simply too much competition. A too broad offering will confuse your users and will not set your app as a leader in the specific field you operate in. It is essential to hone in on certain market segments which you can serve better, more profitable or more cost-effectively.

Based on UX research, you can construct several personas representing market segments that your digital product should provide an ideal customer and onboarding experience to. UX research and persona development are addressed in detail in other lessons.

Step 3: Identify user's goals and prioritise tasks to accomplish these goals in a personalised manner

Now it is time to identify what the end goals of the users are considering their deeper needs and motivations. Reaching these goals is referred to as value creation for users, and you must help users accomplish these goals. Create value and provide something of significant value to them.

You can use the Jobs-to-be-done (JTBD) methodology to analyse and clearly define user goals. This will be discussed in detail in the lesson on UX innovation.

Once you identified user goals and tasks, you must prioritise these tasks so that only the absolute essential tasks are required from users to perform first. For example, if you need personal information from the user, only ask the most essential information at first. At a later stage, after the user already started using your app productively for some time, additional information can be asked.

Give preference to the most important user tasks during design and development so that these tasks are as easy and streamlined as possible for the user to perform. For example, if a top priority task for a health app is to gather and process food intake data, invest your money and time to make it as simple as possible for the user to input food consumption data. Less important tasks must be slowly incorporated or exposed to the user as the user become increasingly familiar with your app over time.

Do not fall into the common trap of postponing medium to lower priority tasks indefinitely, because this will cause stagnation.

Personalise the prioritisation of tasks and overall journey depending on the specific goals and needs of the user. Digital adoption can be made much more attractive and easier if the onboarding journey is personalised.

Step 4: App marketing

Target users of your app must be made aware of your offering, and why it is better, more convenient than other apps or traditional channels. This is especially important for new markets or users who have not adopted digital channels yet. This assures you that you are the first to capture them digitally. This is known as “app marketing” or “marketing of new technology products” but the same principles of traditional and digital marketing apply.

Use a variety of channels to reach potential customers and focus on the channels that your target user utilises.

- Some users may use a search engine to find a solution that you can provide. To reach them you need to have a good search engine optimised website. Also, have a blog and many useful how-to or interesting videos on video sharing platforms such as YouTube.
- Referrals by friends, family and colleagues are very important, therefore implement a good social media, referral scheme, word-of-mouth, and viral marketing strategy.
- Other users may discover your app on social media. It’s important to have a solid social media strategy in place, and a good landing page, as part of your website, to link potential users from social media posts.
- Other users may discover your app on the app store of the operating system they use. Make certain that your app is easy to discover; learn more on the topic of app store optimisation. Also make certain that your app has a professional-looking icon, has a good description, descriptive name, screenshots that illustrate the benefits of using your app, and encourage users to review your app. Reply to negative app reviews and address their concerns to the maximum extent reasonably possible. Reviews and user feedback is very useful and important to improve your app.
- A digital advertising strategy may be very powerful and although it is paid for, you can target it very well to potential user groups.
- Overall, content marketing is essential to make your app discoverable through various channels.

Because your app or software product is probably targeted at a digitally savvy audience, digital and social media marketing methods may be especially effective. The potential user must be assisted through marketing or other forms of communication, to visualise how the app will benefit them. Illustrate why they should switch to digital channels in general or your app and make it clear that it is not difficult to do so. To make use of the very effective persuasion techniques of similarity and social proof, mention that many other people like them have already started using your app or solution successfully and are now happier than ever because of your solution. Emphasise similarity, so that older or less savvy users know that many others also include older or less savvy individuals.

Like in conventional marketing, emphasise the overall goal or deeper emotional need that the user will get, not the features of the app. And keep in mind that an emotional appeal is much more persuasive than a rational appeal. Use an emotional angle or emotional reasons for using your app and the emotional advantages it delivers, rather than a purely rational or fact-based approach to explain the value of your app. This applies to both business and personal users.

Use a variety of communication channels to illustrate why your app or digital product is better, safer, more convenient, and cost-efficient compared to traditional ways, or other apps:

- Posters and banners inside your shops or outlets if you are a traditional retailer, clearly visible from waiting areas or queues. This will make current customers aware that they can switch to your digital channels without having to go to and wait in your physical stores.
- Posters in shop door windows that make use of the opportunity to convert traditional customers outside of business hours to make use of your digital channels that are open throughout the day and night and on weekends, and provide clear, simple instructions on the poster to do so.

- SMS messages with attractive incentives like free cellular data or airtime, which is especially attractive to users in developing countries. This may work very well to encourage digital adoption amongst users not familiar with digital technology.
- Viral marketing like humorous Tic Toc or WhatsApp videos, or memes.

Your marketing or awareness creation messages must be simple, short, relatable and make ample use of pictures, illustrations, animations and videos.

Step 5: Make initial discovery of app or service easy through various channels

Website

After customers decided to try your digital product, it must be intuitive how to get hold of the app or service. You must have a website for your product, even if your product is a mobile app or a digital product not dependent on the web. The website must be search engine optimised so users will find your website easily.

From your website, have a very clear link to your digital product. It may be part of your website in case you have a cloud-based software-as-a-service solution.

In case your offering is a downloadable app or software, you must provide a clear link to the appropriate app store. In this case, make it clear which link or button the user should use depending on their device or operating system. If possible, auto-detect the device and operating system the user is using while visiting your website so that the appropriate link or button can be displayed clearly.

Email & SMS marketing

The same applies to email and SMS marketing. Apart from a link to your website's dedicated landing page that provides more information about your app or software, have a link to the specific app on the specific app store to download it easily. By the way, email and SMS marketing is not dead or outdated, it is still is very effective marketing channels, especially for app and software marketing.

In promotional messages or advertising of your app, show the app icon and exact name as it appears on the different app stores so that there is no confusion.

USSD codes

In the case of USSD codes, show how to use the correct USSD code for the different functions, and especially the code to get to or initiate the first menu. A business card with a USSD code is ideal for carrying in a wallet, and a fridge magnet or even a calendar or poster is ideal if the user may need to be reminded what the code is at their house or another location where they may need to access your USSD service.

In countries where many citizens have low income and where data is very expensive, users are highly price-sensitive and app usage may depend on how large the app is to download, how frequently it must be updated, and how much data it uses. Inform these users exactly how much download and use will cost in terms of initial pricing and data costs. Try to minimise data usage and if possible, arrange with the telecommunications companies to pay the data costs on your user's behalf.

Did you know?

More than half of digital product users will leave a site if it takes longer than 3 seconds to load. Therefore, onboarding of your user is extremely important as you will be able to determine a lot of issues that your site might have

Step 6: Position your product and set expectations with descriptive, relevant, and persuasive content

When a potential user is made aware of your promotional message, make it clear what value your product offers and what need your product solves. Although marketing theory tells you to sell a solution, not a product or service, customers are sick of marketing content trying to sell some vague 'solution' or a magic cure. They want to know what this product entails, so be clear to set expectations right. Also, be price transparent to price-sensitive customers. Your Unique Selling Proposition must be clear.

Contrasting your solution to an existing solution is often very effective to help users understand what you offer. For example, you may say "it's like Facebook but focused on networking amongst people in your industry."

Step 7: Encourage users to try your app, and handling of objections

After potential customers were made aware of your app or digital solution, they need to be encouraged to try and evaluate it. In other words, you must encourage the trial of your app. Awareness of the existence of your app and its advantages and how it could help your users reach their goals is not enough. Strong persuasion or nudging is necessary to convince users to try your app in an app store or internet which is already overloaded with possible customer solutions. This is especially important for slow adopters of new technology.

Appropriate channels to encourage trial include:

- All channels listed in the awareness creation step discussed earlier.
- In case you have an existing brick-and-mortar business, email and/or social media marketing may be ideal. Send email or social media marketing messages to existing customers with known email addresses or social media profiles but who did not adopt your app or other digital channels yet. Email and other social media diffused through the population much faster than other digital touchpoints.

A variety of persuasive techniques should be used for the different target audiences. These techniques can also be used in conjunction with the previous awareness creation step.

- Emphasise the user's current pain points who relies on physical channels, traditional solutions. Put your app or digital solution forward as the ideal solution to alleviate these pain points and meet their needs more effectively.
- Use social proof by showing how many individuals already made the digital transition to your solution without encountering any difficulty or safety issues.
- Use the similarity principle by showing how people who are like your target audience happily adopted your app. This is especially important if your target audience includes digitally illiterate individuals.

It's essential to tailor persuasive messages or techniques to the different target audiences because different personas are motivated and persuaded by different goals.

An important task in this step is objection handling, in other words, you must anticipate objections or reasons customers may think of for not wanting to use your app. If there is an elephant in the room, or an obvious concern like the complexity to use the app, high cost or perceived security threat, discuss it openly rather than avoiding the topic. Mention how the concern is addressed, why it should not be an issue of concern, or why it is untrue or irrational. Common objections to app or software adoption, with proposed solutions, are discussed later in this course.

Step 8: Enable signup-free exploration for pre-sign up value illustration

Before expecting a user to sign up or act, let them explore what your app can offer them first. The only effort on behalf of the user at this stage may be for them to select what type of target customer they are so that personalised or segment-relevant value can be illustrated. For example, if you sell ceramic tiles, you may want to ask the user whether they are a professional builder, a homeowner, or a DIY enthusiast. This will enable you to show them content at their level of experience and tailored for their needs.

Step 9: Pre-signup use, investment of effort and getting some value (optional)

After a user explores your product and considers trying it, but is not convinced yet to sign up, even just for a free trial, you may offer the opportunity to let them partially use your app without signing up at all. Maybe you will allow them to make use of it for just a few sessions or let them perform a few important tasks. If a user spent some time using your product, they may feel that they already committed to it and will want to continue using it otherwise their initial time and effort investment was wasted.

A user could have designed or built something very useful on your app, which can't be exported. A good example may be a drawing app where the user may have created good designs on the app while just exploring before signing up. It may be saved on their browser's cache or local database, a cloud database with a cookie or IP address as reference. This will however only be suitable for insensitive information. If the user values what they created they may be encouraged to sign up for a free trial, or even a paid version.

Pre-signup and pre-trial use may also be a powerful social marketing technique. If a user can do something interesting and it's sharable, they may actively spread their creation via word-of-mouth or viral marketing. Perhaps the original user may not be ready for sign-up yet, but their contacts may be more willing to sign up.

Step 10: Quick, easy, minimalist, risk and cost-free initial signup and trial

Once the user is convinced that your app may offer them something valuable, they won't browse away and will give you some extra time and opportunity to convince them. At this stage of the sales funnel the customer is not ready for any financial commitment yet. As soon as they start showing interest in your solution and don't simply browse away, they can be a good sales lead and you have a wonderful opportunity to impress them so that they can move further through the sales funnel.

Therefore, enable commitment-free, cost-free, and risk-free signup for an initial trial period.

In case you provide a financial service or if sales are involved, don't force a user at this stage to link card details. For risk-averse users, provide a temporary virtual wallet or temporary, free account so that they don't have to link their existing accounts, but still can experiment with and build confidence using the app or service. Then once they are comfortable with your app, enable them to upgrade to a premium account. The excuse that you want credit card details just to identify the person is not good enough anymore, it makes customers immediately suspicious. The only legitimate reason to ask for credit card information is to attract users who are serious about considering your product. Users won't always remember

to cancel the subscription at the end of the free trial. However, this is unethical, representing dark UX patterns and may cause severe brand reputation damage.

During the signup process, ask only for the bare minimum information needed to get started with a value-illustrating first task or accomplishment of a user goal. Ask these essential pieces of information over consecutive steps in the onboarding process, with just one or two questions per screen, as long-winded questionnaires are intimidating and may frighten the user to give up on the signup process.

Have a progress indicator or stepper to illustrate to the user how quickly they are moving through the signup process. Make it clear that the process is short and that they are making good, quick progress as they move along the signup process.

Leave any nice-to-have information for later harvesting as the user gets progressively onboarded over a long term to unlock more advanced features.

You may wonder how long the free trial period should be. The answer depends on how long the user is likely to take before experiencing value. If your app or software are complex, require a lot of learning, like cloud computing platforms, a long period like a year may be needed. Beware of too short trial periods.

Step 11: Help users to experience value and initial/small goal attainment ASAP

Make it easy to accomplish something of value to them as quickly as possible, especially through quick wins. Quick wins in this context may be, for example in the case of a healthy eating app, showing the user a very popular, most tasty yet very healthy and easy way to prepare their very next meal.

Handy tip 1: If you have a garden planning app, use the user's current location to pull an aerial map of the property, and auto-generate a garden layout on the available space that include popular plant species suitable for the particular season and the local climate. A large part of the user's job has already been done, and then the user should be able to easily edit or adapt it further to perfection according to personal preferences and circumstances. This way you can illustrate the value in a very short time, which will entice the user to adopt the app and become a regular user.

Handy tip 2: Provide a choice of appropriate templates so they can start on a semi-completed basis. For example, if you have a job search app, you can provide a variety of CV templates for different types of industries, countries, languages, job levels and corporate cultures. Make certain that you have a good search, navigation and filtering capability to enable users to easily find the most appropriate template.

Provide step-by-step queues on what to do next to accomplish their first small goal as soon as possible. Onboarding tips and guidance can be in a variety of formats, and unfortunately, there is no consensus. To encourage adoption of your app, the following may be particularly effective:

- Welcome message in email, SMS and in-app, with instructions on how to become immediately productive. Have a descriptive heading and content.
- 'Guided tour' for a particular task: Upon signup ask the user what task he/she like to perform first, then provide on-screen highlighted, short and simple tips on where to click/tap next throughout the journey to accomplish this task.
- Provide short, simple how-to videos. For low user incomes and where data costs are high, consider SVG graphics or similar low-data video format.
- For users who are not digitally savvy, provide business card sized, durable printed instruction cards with instructions on how to perform key tasks on phone using USSD code or how to navigate the app. Have two separate cards for these two channels because many new users are likely to use only one of these channels. It should be in a neat, durable business card format so that it can be placed in the users' wallets.
- In the case of USSD solutions for digitally less savvy users, a sticker with USSD code instructions that the user can stick to the back of their phone can be very effective.

- Fridge magnets and A4 printed posters that users can take home for later reference. This has proven successful in many industries to help remember customers to perform tasks that they normally without help won't easily recall themselves.
- Conventional brochures at store brochure stands, inside and outside the shop, with brochures for the app, internet and USSD banking instructions, may be very effective to drive app adoption.

Praise your users on the small accomplishment of their first goals. This may boost their self-confidence and motivation to keep using your app.

Personalise the onboarding tips messages and guidance because the first task to experience value differs widely amongst different users with different goals and motivations. For example, for some users of a nutrition app, quick value after signing up may be to identify a nutritious but low kilojoule recipe, while for others it may be to identify a high kilojoule, energy-rich snack to give energy for an endurance race.

Step 12: Encourage repeat usage

After the initial task or goal has been accomplished on your app, encourage, and help the user to do another desirable and user-relevant task. It can be a more complex task or a similar task as repetition assists in understanding. This is important because accomplishing a goal or task once only will unlikely convince the user to keep using the product. A key strategy to successfully onboard a user is to help and encourage them to perform a task several times on your app so that it can become a habit. Repetition will enable the user to become faster, better, more productive, confident, and committed.

Part of learning a new habit or adopting a new tool is to let go of the old habit or discontinuing using the old tool. This can be done by contrasting how much easier, better, and cheaper it is to use your solution compared to the user's current solution.

In showing that your app is more cost-efficient, you may directly point out the direct cost if your solution is indeed cheaper. Make use of visual aids like graphs or infographics to make comparisons between your solution and an existing solution.

To convince users to let go of the old habit or tool and adopt your new solution may not be easy because people tend to resist change, especially people with a less open type of personality. They may fear that your solution may not be as good as the old solution. Therefore, address their fears and illustrate to them how you addressed those risks and why they can rest assure that their fears are not an issue.

Step 13: Engage users

To keep users growing into the onboarding process and reduce app abandonment, make using your app or digital product a pleasure, adventure, and memorable and life-enhancing experience. The app must help customers to make their daily lives increasingly better, easier and get their tasks done quicker.
Continuously engage users, provide positive reinforcement, utilise personalised motivations to keep using the range of offerings. Gamification may be considered to help with this, but it must be a well-designed, motivating and value-adding gamification strategy. Build an online or social community around key interest areas of your offering or industry. The potential for building digital communities through a platform business model are endless. Encourage users to share their accomplishments and positive experiences with others through online communities or social media because word-of-mouth may be the best marketing method to facilitate the adoption of your app.

Step 14: End-of-free-trial interventions (where applicable)

At the end of a free trial, if you offered it, which is often highly recommended, you may see that users have used the trial period in different ways. Some users may have actively engaged with your product and already made it part of their work or personal life. For them, the best might be to consider them well on their way to becoming a loyal customer and you may move forward with the next onboarding steps.

Other users may have started using it, but usage is irregular, and they invested only a little time into learning your product. If usage was concentrated during the late period of the free trial and an effort trying your app out before end-of-trial, the following can be considered: if they did not cancel the free trail, move forward with the onboarding steps. If they did cancel, consider extending their free trial with another reasonable period to experience value, followed through with supporting and encouraging emails or messages on the communication channel of their choice.

If you see that usage was limited to the early part of the free trial and it dropped off in the later period, you can consider these users as high churn risk users. Consider extending their free trial with another reasonable period to experience value, followed through with supporting and encouraging messages. Emphasise your messages on getting to try your app again.

Those users who only used your app once after signing up can be considered fully churned. It may be because they simply did not get time to try your app, which is very common. Again, consider extending their free trial with another reasonable period to experience value, followed through with supporting and encouraging messages. For them, general awareness messages on your app's potential value, as if they are still in the very early part of the sales funnel, will be needed. However, this may also point to insufficient execution of earlier onboarding steps. You may need to revisit these earlier steps if use-only-once is a very common problem.

Managing churned users is described in more detail in a later step.

Step 15: Continuous onboarding to progressively expose more advanced features and gather more user data for further helpful personalisation and increased value creation

Onboarding never ends. It is a continuous process to help the user in using increasingly advanced features and gain more value from your product. It is your job to help basic users become more advanced users, and infrequent users to become regular users.

Part of ongoing onboarding is to help existing users use new features. All users, including experienced power users, must be onboarded or guided in clever but useful ways. Of course, as your app evolves and as you innovate and introduce new business models, new features will be introduced, others may be replaced, and the appearance and availability of functionalities will increasingly be personalised. This is yet another way to increase engagement and loyalty. Just be careful not to let the app become overpowering, which is why the personalisation of the user interface will increasingly become more important.

Lastly, any new updates, major changes or replacement or discontinuation of features need to be handled with care. Many users don't like changes at all, even if it means that your new product is better. In this case, ongoing onboarding should help users to adapt to these changes as painlessly as possible. In general, whenever you replace a feature, make it as clear as possible where to find and how to use the new feature. If you discontinue a feature, explain why, and provide alternative solutions to your users, even if it means referring them to another app or competitor in case, they are not your target market anymore. A great solution adopted by many apps and software programs is to continue supporting the classic version of your app while allowing new users, as well as original users more open to the new app, to use the new version. The old and new versions may be two different, separate apps, or they may live within the same app and the user can toggle with a button between the old and new versions. Communicate to users of the old version for how long you will support the old app and help them to get to know the new app. If many users would like to remain using the old app and if they are a profitable segment, it may be best to keep supporting the old version for as many years it will still be profitable and won't cause brand damage to kill your old app.

Step 16: Follow up and nurture relationships and re-target churning users

Unfortunately, losing users' time is a very common problem. It's a well-known fact that attracting brand new customers is much more difficult and expensive than trying to retain existing users. Existing users are already aware of your app, so you don't have to use expensive or time-consuming awareness creation marketing methods to find them.

Use predictive analytics to identify users likely to abandon your app, also known as churn, and provide them with messages personalised to their needs to motivate them to adopt your solution. Direct them seamlessly to the next step in using your app to experience great value. Provide churning users with incentives if awareness messages didn't work, like special offers to subscribe or competitions for completing a task.

For high-value customers, appoint relationship or customer success managers to provide them with personal attention. Gather user feedback on the digital adoption process and how it can be improved. Then act upon such insights, and introduce new innovations, to continuously improve your app adoption process. Feedback could be gathered through user research.

Step 17: Encourage word-of-mouth, social sharing and evangelism

A powerful method to encourage the adoption of your app is through word-of-mouth marketing. Encourage and incentivise your existing users to help family members, friends and colleagues who still use older technologies or no technology at all, or a competitor's app, to download and start using your app. A referral program may be particularly effective.

Step 18: Continuous improvement of the onboarding process

A product that stagnates, even how well it is working and how much it is loved at present, will die if it does not evolve along with changing customer needs, trends, technology, and competitive forces. Continuous improvement is made possible through a strong innovation process which will be discussed during future lessons on UX innovation and user co-creation. Continuous improvement does not necessarily mean keep introducing more features and complexity, but rather the streamlining of the user's overall quest to meet their needs. This may include replacement or discontinuation of features, clever hiding of user-specific irrelevant features, merging or integration of different apps, spritting out of side apps, and regularly updating the branding and look and feel of the app.

Conclusion

Onboarding is key to the success of your digital product because it encourages users to use your app. Onboarding starts with the identification of your target users and making them aware of your digital product and how it can solve their needs. It must be easy for users to find your app or product, and to explore what it has to offer them before requiring them to commit anything like signing up or paying. We learnt how important it is to make signup as easy and risk-free as possible, to immediately let the user experience success and accomplish a goal followed by accomplishment of several more goals, follow up with churning users, engage users, encourage positive word-of-mouth and continually improve the onboarding process.

Ending off this onboarding lesson with a quote from Scott Belsky, creator of Behance. Scott stated that the rule of thumb for UX: More options, more problems.

In essence this means that you need to keep your digital product or app as simple as possible. Don't provide too many options to your users, as this will confuse them and end up making a lot of work for your UX team.

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